Where You Are: Organizing Mom's Finances and What Comes After It

The nine steps of the Medicaid Planning Roadmap, with yours marked.

When the care bills start arriving, it can feel as if every money question needs an answer at once. It doesn't. There's an order to it, and you're near the beginning.

This page shows the whole road, where you are on it, and what comes next.

Phase 1 · Assess

Understand where you are today.

1 **Understand** Care Needs → Levels of Care & Costs → Care Plan
You finish with: Immediate Care Needs Assessment

2 **Organize** Income & Assets → Ownership & Expenses → Financial File
You finish with: Financial Snapshot & Care Cost Analysis

You are here. This step is about getting Mom's finances onto paper: what she owns, what income she receives and what her care costs. You finish it with what you know, what is still missing and what care is costing each month written down in one place, ready for a professional to review.

3 **Assess** Care & Nonfinancial Eligibility → Income & Assets → Barriers & Readiness
You finish with: Medicaid Readiness Assessment

Phase 2 · Plan

Develop and implement your strategy.

4 **Plan** Barriers & Issues → Priorities & Professional Team → Written Plan
You finish with: Medicaid Action Plan

5 **Legal** Authority & Documents → Property, Trusts & Transfers → Attorney Review
You finish with: Legal Issues & Attorney Review Brief

6 **Financial** Costs & Runway → Asset Treatment & Tools → Strategy & Documentation
You finish with: Financial Strategy & Implementation Plan

Phase 3 · Secure

Secure benefits, protect assets, and maintain eligibility.

7 **Apply** Prepare → Submit → Manage
You finish with: Medicaid Application File

8 **Protect** What May Be Protected → What May Remain Exposed → What Needs Ongoing Attention
You finish with: Asset Protection Report

9 **Maintain** Ongoing Requirements → Changes & Renewals → Maintenance System
You finish with: Medicaid Maintenance Plan

What this step produces

A Financial Snapshot & Care Cost Analysis: Mom's income, assets, expenses, insurance and current care costs in one place, with a note of whose name is on each item and what hasn't turned up yet. The step moves from income and assets, to ownership and expenses, to a file of the records behind them.

Your part is gathering and labeling. If several of you are sharing the work, AARP suggests writing down who is responsible for what; it isn't a legal document, but it can make everyone's role clear. [2]

The snapshot is a family's information, organized. It isn't a decision about Medicaid or about Mom's money.

What happens next

Your Medicaid planner reviews the snapshot, confirms who owns each asset and how each account is titled, and notes what is still missing. Unusual withdrawals, gifts or transfers aren't judged at this point. They are carried forward as questions for review.

Then comes step three, Assess, which starts from the picture you've built here. The steps after it bring in other professionals, and the legal questions on this road go to an elder law attorney. The Consumer Financial Protection Bureau's guide for people managing a relative's money gives the same advice: get legal advice, and be very careful, about decisions that may affect Medicaid eligibility. [1]

Who is involved, by role

- You and your family: finding, gathering, labeling, writing down.
- Mom: what she knows and remembers about her own accounts, if she's able to tell you.
- The bank, the insurance company and the pension office: what each account or policy is, and whose name is on it.
- The facility's or care provider's business office: what the bill includes and what is billed separately.
- Your Medicaid planner: reviews the snapshot, confirms ownership and titling, notes what is missing, and organizes the records for the next steps.
- An elder law attorney, a licensed insurance professional and a licensed financial professional: the legal, insurance and financial questions that come up in the later steps.

What this page doesn't promise

How long any step takes, who will be available, or how things turn out. It doesn't say Mom will qualify for anything or that any amount will be protected, and it isn't legal, financial or tax advice. Families move through the steps at different speeds.

Ready for the next step?

You know where you are and what comes next. The planning interview is the next thing to do from here: it asks about your family's situation and gives you a free planning report you can bring to any conversation about paying for care.

Get Your Free Planning Report ›

WHERE THIS COMES FROM

The nine steps are the Medicaid Planning Roadmap's own. The advice to get legal advice before decisions that may affect Medicaid eligibility is the Consumer Financial Protection Bureau's, and the suggestion to write down who in the family does what is AARP's.

1. Consumer Financial Protection Bureau, Managing someone else's money: Help for agents under a power of attorney
2. AARP, Legal Checklist for Caregivers With Aging Parents